



MODULE 2

Coaching style and autonomy

Do you motivate players, or do you teach them to motivate themselves?

CORE THEORY

Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan, 1985) shows that people are most motivated when three basic needs are met: autonomy (I have choice), competence (I can do it), and relatedness (I belong). Controlling coaches who rely solely on pressure and enforcement undermine intrinsic motivation. Autonomy-supportive coaching demonstrably leads to better performance, less burnout, and higher long-term enjoyment of sport.

Source: Deci & Ryan (1985, 2000) · Mageau & Vallerand (2003) · Amorose & Anderson-Butcher (2007)

"The best coaches create conditions where players want to surpass themselves, not because they have to, but because they want to."

Daniel Pink

"Control is the enemy of autonomy. And autonomy is the engine of growth."

Edward Deci

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 Do your players genuinely have input in training content, rules, or team agreements? Or is it fake autonomy?
- 2 When do you give instructions vs. when do you ask questions? What is the ratio?
- 3 Which player on your team needs the most structured environment, and which needs the most freedom? Do you treat them differently?
- 4 How do you react when a player wants to try something different than what you suggest? What does that say about your style?
- 5 What would change in your training if you let players design one session entirely themselves?

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **Drive**
Daniel Pink
Why: The science of motivation in one accessible book. Intrinsic vs. extrinsic, and what coaches get wrong about rewards.
- **Mindset**
Carol Dweck
Why: Fixed vs. growth mindset. How you as a coach create, or destroy, a growth climate with your words and reactions.
- **Why Motivating People Doesn't Work and What Does**
Susan Fowler
Why: Practical book on optimal motivation. Translates SDT directly into coaching practice.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **The Puzzle of Motivation**
Daniel Pink (TED Talk)
ted.com/talks/dan_pink_the_puzzle_of_motivation
Watch: the Candle Problem experiment. External rewards kill creative thinking.
- **The Power of Believing You Can Improve**
Carol Dweck (TED Talk)
ted.com/talks/carol_dweck_the_power_of_believing_that_you_can_improve
How "not yet" is more powerful than "no." Applicable in every coaching interaction.

**PODCASTS**

- **The Science of Sport**
Episode on intrinsic motivation in youth sport
scienceofsport.com
- **Kwame Christian: Negotiate Anything**
How to move people without forcing them
negotiateanything.com

ACTION THIS WEEK

Observe yourself for one week: note each time you give an instruction vs. ask a question. What is the ratio? What do you want to change?

One way I will give more autonomy to my players:
